Aurangzeb: Religious Policy, North India & the Rajputs

Continuous at-a-glance rail: chronology, law, jizyah, temple evidence, North Indian unrest, differentiated incorporation and the Rajput rupture.
Reading rule: date the measure, identify the source and locality, then separate hierarchy, enforcement, alliance politics and later memory.
Topic boundary: Topic 21 ends with the 1657-58 succession result; Topic 23 begins where the Deccan-Maratha war becomes the main story.

01. Chronology and ownership

1658
1667
c.1669
1672
1675
1678
1679
1681
1698
1699
1704
1707
1712

1658 accession result →
1667 Jai Singh dies →
c.1669 temple order / Jat climate →
1672 Satnamis, Narnaul →
1675 Guru Tegh Bahadur executed →
1678 Jaswant Singh dies, Jamrud →
1679 jizyah + Rajput crisis
Jan. 1681 Prince Akbar revolts →
1698 Ajit Singh recognised (limited) →
1699 Khalsa founded →
1704 southern suspension →
1707 Aurangzeb dies →
1712 jizyah abolished

Topic boundary

- Topic 21 ends with the 1657-58 succession result.
- Topic 22 owns law, jizyah, temple evidence, North Indian unrest and the Marwar-Mewar rupture.
- Topic 23 owns Shivaji, the Marathas, the Deccan war and the jagirdari crisis.

Controlling question

- How far did sharper hierarchy and Rajput mismanagement weaken Mughal legitimacy in North India?
- Open with a dated verdict so unlike developments are never merged into one script.

Why chronology first

- The c.1669 temple-order climate is not the 1672 Satnami rising, the 1675 execution or the 1679 succession dispute.
- Dating blocks two recurring errors: importing the whole Deccan war, and turning every event into one communal chain.

Answer line: Topic 22 is a North Indian legitimacy problem framed by dated policies and a damaged Rajput alliance.

02. Court-symbolic periodisation

continuity
jharoka
Nauroz
coin formulae
muhtasib
mosque repair
1669-79
war years

Phase 1 — early continuity

- Orthodox preference exists, but no instant break in practice.
- The emperor still works through established administrative channels and composite recruitment.

Phase 2 — court-symbolic turn

- Jharoka darshan ends; Nauroz loses its court place; music at court is restricted.
- Coin formulae are regulated — coinage was a standing public declaration of rulership, so the regulation altered the sovereign idiom itself.
- Muhtasibs are appointed and mosque repair is patronised; together these change the public idiom of sovereignty first.

Phase 3 — c.1669-79

- Sharper legal-symbolic differentiation: temple controversies, the 1679 jizyah and the Rajput breach.
- Coercion is real, but locality and source type still matter.

Phase 4 — late war years

- Recruitment continues, exceptions survive, and the 1704 southern suspension shows wartime flexibility.
- Uneven enforcement does not cancel symbolic force.

Evidence control before scaling any anecdote

- Ask five things of every reported measure: exact date, type of action, source genre, locality, and evidence of implementation or exception.
- Each court-symbolic item — coin formulae included — needs its own date, genre and locality before it enters an answer.
- Popular lists flatten decades of orders into one folklore package; periodisation restores sequence and proportion.
- Distinguish public idiom from administrative order, and administrative order from social penetration.

Answer line: periodise the reign so that symbolic change, harder legal differentiation and late wartime exceptions appear in sequence.

03. Law, sovereignty and jizyah

sharia
zawabit
Fatawa-i-Alamgiri
1679
exemptions
separate treasury
1704
1712

Legal grammar

- Sharia = legal idiom and moral preference; zawabit = ruler-made regulation and sovereign discretion.
- Fatawa-i-Alamgiri is an imperially sponsored Hanafi compendium, not a modern constitution and not a self-executing code.

Authority chain

- Sharia opinion -> emperor frames the order -> provincial officer or qazi applies, negotiates or evades -> locality absorbs or resists.
- The emperor still appoints, taxes, wages war, grants exceptions and settles politically.

Jizyah as a legal category

- A poll tax marking differentiated non-Muslim subjecthood; not land revenue and not customs duty.
- Women, children, indigent persons and some dependants could fall outside routine collection.

Why 1679 mattered

- Public assertion of Islamic rulership.
- Patronage toward jurists and ulama.
- Symbolic reversal of Akbarian precedent.
- New collector-subject friction and openings for corruption.

Where the money went

- Receipts were placed in a separate treasury for needy Muslims and the ulama.
- They did not simply relieve the general treasury, so the tax cannot be read as a neutral supplement to ordinary agrarian finance.
- The earmarking repeats the same public message about status that the reimposition itself sent.

Why fiscal neatness fails

- Satish Chandra cites a large official total, yet also stresses corruption and political failure; a court claim is not realised revenue.
- Crop-failure remissions and the 1704 southern suspension show chronology and regional flexibility inside a discriminatory policy.
- Formal abolition follows under Jahandar Shah in 1712.

Answer line: Aurangzeb tightened legal-symbolic hierarchy through jizyah without abolishing sovereign discretion.

04. Temple-policy evidence ladder

c.1669
Kashi Vishvanath
Keshava Rai, Mathura
Jodhpur
Udaipur
grants
counter-evidence

1. General or provincial order — proves policy language and target category, never uniform empire-wide action.
2. Site-specific destruction, conversion or defacement — proves coercive action at a named place, not the whole empire.
3. Wartime punishment in rebellious zones — explains timing and target, but does not dissolve the religious dimension.
4. Grants, protection or non-interference elsewhere — proves continued patronage, and does not erase punitive action.
5. Material remains and later complaint records — prove survival, damage or repair, never motive on their own.

Named cases to cite

- The c.1669 order sits in a court-chronicle setting linked with objectionable teaching.
- Kashi Vishvanath and the Keshava Rai temple at Mathura are the major site cases.
- During the 1679-80 Rajput war, old-standing temples in the Jodhpur and Udaipur areas were also destroyed.

Method and caution

- Dated site -> source type -> stated context -> actual action -> regional reach -> counter-evidence.
- The formal old/new distinction mattered, yet it did not settle every case.
- Reject both caricatures, and do not let present-day litigation language replace dated medieval evidence.

Answer line: reject both caricatures — neither universal destruction nor blanket exoneration fits the dated site-by-site evidence.

05. North Indian unrest and the Sikh case

Gokula c.1669
Rajaram
Churaman
Satnamis 1672
Bundelas
1675
1699

Jats — recurrence, not one event

- Mathura-Agra belt; cultivators, zamindars and clan communities.
- Revenue pressure, local power, official coercion and a religious-political climate all mattered.
- Gokula's rising c.1669 was followed by later resistance under Rajaram and then Churaman.
- Do not project the later Bharatpur state backward on to Gokula.

Satnamis, 1672

- A local clash near Narnaul escalated into cultivator-artisan mobilisation and was suppressed by imperial force.
- Neither an all-India revolt nor a purely theological story.

Bundelas

- Champat Rai and later Chhatrasal belong to a frontier world of chiefship, Mughal extraction, service and rebellion.
- Their chronology cannot be collapsed into jizyah alone.

Guru Tegh Bahadur

- Guruship 1664; eastern travels; return to Punjab; execution at Delhi in November 1675.
- Persian security framing, Sikh martyr memory and later Kashmir-linked tradition must be weighed together.

Why the Sikh case needs balance

- Satish Chandra treats the punishment as unjustified, yet no single transparent contemporary narrative settles every detail.
- The 1699 Khalsa under Guru Gobind Singh is a major later consequence, but 1675 is not an automatic switch for every later Sikh development.
- Topic 22 owns the Aurangzeb-period policy connection; later Sikh institutional history belongs elsewhere.

Answer line: these movements differ in social base and locality, yet together they show how North Indian legitimacy frayed.

06. Rajput alliance before the breach

watan
mansab
jagir
honour
succession recognition
Jai Singh
Jaswant Singh

Component of the bargain	What the Rajput house received	What the empire received
Watan authority	Hereditary control of the home territory was recognised.	A stable regional intermediary who governed on the empire's behalf.
Mansab and jagir	Imperial rank, assignment income and career advance.	Trained commanders and cavalry for distant campaigns.
Honour and precedence	Standing at court, titles and public status.	Visible proof that the empire ruled a composite nobility.
Succession recognition	Predictable handling of a disputed tika.	Orderly transfer without a frontier war.
Military service	Shared prestige of imperial victories.	Reliable manpower and local intelligence.

Baseline before 1678

- Aurangzeb worked with leading Rajput rulers early in the reign: Jai Singh shaped the 1665 settlement with Shivaji, and Jaswant Singh continued in major service.
- So the Marwar crisis was not the expression of a permanent anti-Rajput plan running from 1658.
- The bargain was unequal, but it stayed stable while Mughal guarantees remained credible.

Answer line: define the alliance as an exchange system first; only then does the rupture acquire its political weight.

07. Differentiated incorporation

mansabdars
Amber
Bikaner
Bundi
Kota
administrative need
sharper hierarchy

What continued

- Hindu, Rajput and some Maratha mansabdars remained in imperial service after 1679.
- Houses such as Amber, Bikaner, Bundi and Kota stayed inside the Mughal system.
- Administrative need and rank-jagir incentives kept composite recruitment alive.

What sharpened

- Some discriminatory orders on appointments and customs were issued, modified or locally evaded.
- Jizyah and temple controversies changed the public hierarchy within which service continued.
- Elite inclusion is not a claim about mass religious equality.

Tempting sentence	Why it fails	Exam-safe replacement
“Aurangzeb expelled Hindus from service.”	Named houses demonstrably continued in service after 1679.	Composite service survived, on sharper and more differentiated terms.
“Continued service proves there was no discrimination.”	It answers a recruitment question, not a legal-symbolic one.	Inclusion in office is not identical with equal public standing.
“Late-reign percentages settle the debate.”	Source, denominator and rank threshold are rarely specified.	Quote a figure only with its source and rank basis, or argue without it.

Answer line: the correct category is differentiated incorporation — composite service survives under a sharper public hierarchy.

08. Marwar-Mewar rupture

1678
Ajit Singh
khalisa
Inder Singh
ranis' claims
Durgadas
tika at Jodhpur
Raj Singh
Jan. 1681
1698

1. Jaswant Singh dies at Jamrud in 1678, leaving no settled successor in place.
2. Ajit Singh emerges as the posthumous claimant to the Marwar tika.
3. Marwar is taken into khalisa amid disputed succession, debt, withheld revenue and disorder — a step with administrative precedent.
4. Official conduct, searches and imperial intervention in custody make interim control look like conquest and dishonour.
5. Aurangzeb backs Inder Singh for the tika; the Rathor sardars reject the proposed arrangement.
6. The competing claims of the ranis and the Rathor sardars are mishandled rather than settled, so the question of who legitimately spoke for Marwar stayed open.
7. Durgadas Rathore organises resistance and protects Ajit Singh's claim.
8. The Rathors restore Ajit's tika at Jodhpur — a rival investiture performed by the clan in its own capital, not an imperial grant, so a contested succession becomes two investitures.
9. Rana Raj Singh of Mewar opposes the occupation and interference, and supports the Rathors; Aravalli terrain raises imperial cost.
10. Prince Akbar revolts in January 1681 with Rathor support; Aurangzeb splits the coalition by letters and manoeuvre, and Akbar flees to the Deccan.

Evidence base

- Waqa-i-Ajmer and the Jodhpur Hukumat-ri-Bahi emphasise disputed succession, debt, official behaviour, Inder Singh's tika and Durgadas's resistance.
- The Marwar sequence itself adds the mishandled claims of the ranis and Rathor sardars and the Rathor restoration of Ajit's tika at Jodhpur.
- They correct a crude annexation story without absolving Aurangzeb; individual rescue stories and later bardic embellishment need provenance control.

Aftermath and cost

- The revolt failed militarily, yet the prestige and trust damage remained.
- Mewar settled after Raj Singh's death, while Rathor war continued intermittently.
- Ajit Singh's recognition in 1698 was limited, not a restoration of the pre-1678 compact.
- The Deccan appears here only as a bounded timing and resource bridge to Topic 23.

Answer line: khalisa was not automatic annexation — the breach came from how succession, rival investiture, custody and honour were handled.

09. Historiography and the verdict

communal monocause
statecraft-only
Satish Chandra
source ladder
graded verdict

Position	What it sees well	What it misses if left unqualified
Communal monocause	Real discrimination and symbolic alienation.	It over-explains a complex reign through a single identity axis.
Statecraft-only revision	Succession disputes, debt, strategy and administrative setting.	It can understate genuine religious coercion and its public meaning.
Balanced view	Orthodoxy plus political context plus locality plus uneven reach.	It demands patient evidence work rather than a slogan answer.

Satish Chandra's formulation

- Aurangzeb is both a victim of circumstances and a maker of the circumstances that trapped him — structure and agency held together.
- On the Rajput policy his judgement is blunt: it was blundering and yielded no real advantage.

Source ladder

- Court chronicles — official idiom and chronology, but selective.
- Farmans and grants — local action, not empire-wide uniformity.
- Local Rajput records — Waqa-i-Ajmer, Hukumat-ri-Bahi.
- Sikh tradition — memory and identity, with genre caution.
- Material remains — survival, damage or repair, never motive alone.

Answer line: differentiated incorporation survived institutionally, yet sharper hierarchy and a mishandled succession widened the gap between coercive reach and legitimacy.

10. Prelims and Mains application

close options
elimination
directive words
structure
qualified verdict

Prelims traps

- Jizyah is not land revenue, customs duty or a tax on every Hindu.
- Jizyah receipts did not simply relieve the general treasury.
- Fatawa-i-Alamgiri is not a constitution or a uniform criminal code.
- Khalisa is not automatic or final annexation.
- Continued Hindu service is not equality.
- The old/new temple distinction mattered formally but did not settle every case.
- One grant or one demolition never proves the whole empire.
- The 1698 recognition is not restoration of the pre-1678 compact.

Mains spine

- Intro — differentiated rule under pressure, dated and localised.
- Body 1 — sharia, zawabit and periodisation, including the regulated coin formulae in the court-symbolic group.
- Body 2 — jizyah and the temple evidence ladder.
- Body 3 — North Indian unrest and the Sikh legitimacy cost.
- Body 4 — the Marwar-Mewar rupture, the mishandled ranis'/sardars' claims and the rival tika at Jodhpur.
- Conclusion — contributory to weakened legitimacy and alliance trust, not the sole cause of decline.

Model closing sentence

- Aurangzeb's legal-symbolic turn and his handling of the Rajput succession weakened trust in Mughal guarantees in North India at precisely the moment deeper southern commitments began, so they contributed to later strain without single-handedly causing imperial decline.

Answer line: name the measure, date it, locate it, weigh its evidence, then give a graded verdict.